

Section B

The second part requires the teacher/examiner* to engage the student in a discussion that, although still relating to the same general topic area and its linked subtopics, moves away from the main focus of the stimulus.

The test time should be divided equally, where appropriate, between Sections A and B. (Some students may need fewer than four minutes to respond fully to the stimulus-related questions.) Progression from Sections A to B should occur without any break in recording.

Centres will need to record the full assessment of all students on either cassette or CD.

All students for this unit will be assessed by Edexcel.

*It is usual for teachers to conduct this assessment with their students during a timetabled assessment window in April/May, although Edexcel offers a visiting examiner facility for centres that have a minimum of ten AS and/or A2 students. For timetable and fee information, please consult the Edexcel website: www.edexcel.org.uk.

Preparation

Students are able to undertake focused preparation for this unit as they can select their preferred general topic area in advance. They should become familiar with the full range of prescribed linked subtopics and, through regular classroom practice, often participate in formatively-assessed discussions. More information and advice on preparing for this unit is given in the *GCE oral training guide*, available on the Edexcel website (www.edexcel.org.uk).

In addition, students will have a 15-minute preparation period when they receive the stimulus immediately prior to the test. They should spend this time studying the stimulus with a view to answering four related questions and considering further discussion points that might follow on. Students will not be allowed access to a dictionary or any other resources at this time. However, it will be possible for students to make notes (no more than one side of A4) which they can refer to during the examination. They must **not** write on the stimulus.

Stimulus

Different sets of stimuli will be produced for each of the above topic areas and will be issued on a random-allocation basis as prescribed in the *Oral handbook for GCE*. Stimuli will be written in French (approximately 70-90 words) at an accessible level for Advanced Subsidiary students and may be supported by a visual. These will be issued to students on the day of their assessment.

Time allocation

The assessment time should, as far as possible, be divided equally between the two sections. Although assessment is qualitative rather than quantitative, the test should take no less than eight minutes and no more than 10 minutes.

1.3 Content

Focus

Although this unit relates to a chosen general topic area, it is essentially designed to assess manipulation and understanding of the French spoken language. The general topic areas should be considered as different contexts in which students can develop, use and understand spoken French language. *Detailed, specialist* French vocabulary or *detailed and specialist* knowledge of the chosen general topic area are **not** required.

Similarly, knowledge of the chosen general topic area in relation to France and other parts of the French-speaking world will **not** be assessed, although students are free to demonstrate this.

General topic areas

Students will choose from **one** of the following general topic areas:

- Youth culture and concerns
- Lifestyle: health and fitness
- The world around us: travel, tourism, environmental issues and the French-speaking world
- Education and employment.

It is important that students choose a general topic area that appeals to them and that they are familiar with.

Linked subtopics

To inform teaching and learning, the following definitive list of linked subtopics has been produced for this unit.

Youth culture and concerns

- Music and fashion
- Technology (eg MP3/blogs/mobile phones/internet/games)
- Relationships (family/friendships and peer pressure)
- Drink, drugs, sex

Lifestyle: health and fitness

- Sport and exercise
- Food and diet
- Health issues (eg smoking, skin cancer, health services)

The world around us: travel, tourism, environmental issues and the French-speaking world

- Tourist information, travel and transport
- Weather (eg natural disasters, climate change)
- Pollution and recycling

Education and employment

- Education (schooling and higher education)
- Education policy and student issues
- The world of work (eg the changing work scene, job opportunities and unemployment)

What students need to learn

Students need to develop language skills that enable them to communicate effectively and confidently on different issues and concerns. They need to give facts, opinions and respond appropriately to unrehearsed and unpredictable questions and statements. They should be used to giving considered and informed responses to open questions.

Students will be assessed on their ability to use language interactively and on the accuracy, range and suitability of the language used.

A maximum of 50 marks will be awarded positively by Edexcel using the assessment criteria grids in Section 1.4.

The assessment criteria reward students for:

- **quality of language** (grammar and structures as listed in *Appendix 6: Grammar lists*, pronunciation, intonation, vocabulary, idiom, range and ability to move away from predictable areas) which has **two** assessment criteria grids:
 - ◆ accuracy AO3 (8 marks)
 - ◆ range of lexis AO3 (8 marks)
- **response** (development) — AO1 (20 marks)
- **understanding** (relevance, opinion) which has **two** assessment criteria grids:
 - ◆ stimulus-specific AO1 (4 marks)
 - ◆ general topic area AO1 (10 marks).